

on wreaking havoc on computers for no apparent reason. Hundreds of new viruses are put out in the wild every year. Starting to feel panicky? One of the best approaches to battle this scourge is to face the problem head-on with the help of antivirus (AV) software.

TEST PROCESS

The antivirus comparison test was done on a system running a P-III 700 processor with 64 MB of RAM. The hard drive used had a capacity of 5.7 GB. The operating system on the test bed was Microsoft Windows 98SE, which was loaded with all the drivers. We took an image of this system before running the tests on each of the AV packages. This disk image was restored after each package was tested.

A good antivirus should be able to find present-day viruses and detect code that could be potentially harmful. And, of course, it should be able to successfully remove the malicious portion of an infected file while leaving the data intact. The emphasis of this test was more on the detection feature, since an antivirus software will usually clean the files it detects (or an update to the definition files will be able to do that).

To run the antivirus software through their paces, we took a collection of around 7,400 viruses along with some of the popular Trojans that are floating around. This collection was calculated to put a lot of strain on the antivirus software. Most of the viruses used were exe and com infecting viruses along with some boot sector viruses, including a mix of actual signature files and infected files. The collection also included Trojans and macro viruses in the archive.

BUSTERS

There were two main virus scanning tests, which included the main uncompressed file scanning test and the compressed virus scanning test that we ran on each of the antivirus software packages. In this comparison test, we only evaluated antivirus software targeted for personal use or a small networked environment. We did not look at enterprise-class antivirus protection suites or client-server based antivirus applications.

The overall score for each software was decided by logging the various features, performance rates, ease of use and test results into a spread-

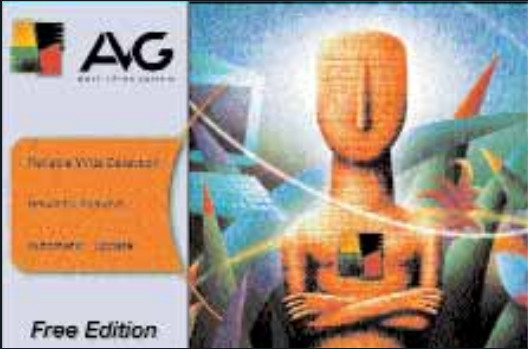
sheet. We also looked at aspects such as availability of regular updates. Based on the weightage assigned to the various parameters, we reached the final score.

Detecting the deadly viruses

Whether a virus is detected or not is the most important performance criterion. We tested the detection rates by two methods—detection of 7,400 viruses in an uncompressed format, and detection of 4,700 viruses in a compressed file. The viruses were a mix of actual signature files and infected files. In the case of infected files, we also looked at the ability of the antivirus software to clean the viruses. Another thing we did was to check the ability of the virus scanners to detect the 10 most common viruses.

Most of the virus scanners performed well in detecting viruses in the uncompressed format, except for QuickHeal, which was able to detect an abysmal 57 per cent of the viruses. The other virus scanners detected around 90 per cent of the viruses. Antivir came out the best, with a 98.26 per cent detection rate, followed closely by InoculateIT. All the virus scanners were able to detect and clean the 10 common viruses.

The differentiation among the virus scanners was quite noticeable when we looked at the detection rates for viruses in compressed files. Three of the eight virus scanners (QuickHeal, eScan, and McAfee) actually buckled under the strain and crashed while attempting to detect viruses in compressed files. Apart from AVG, InoculateIT and Norton, even the others didn't



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More Info on

the test process and the

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